

SOP Manual — Cloud Kitchen and Virtual Brands (India)

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Scope, operating models and roles

A cloud kitchen sells only through delivery and takeaway, so its whole business is speed from order to rider, food that survives a 30-minute ride, and its rating on two or three platforms. This manual covers single-brand, multi-brand (several virtual brands from one kitchen) and shared or rented kitchen spaces. Core kitchen food safety follows the Standalone Restaurant manual (BOH section).

Model	What it means	Key SOP difference
Single-brand	One brand, one kitchen	Simpler menu control
Multi-brand	2-8 virtual brands sharing stations and stock	Station mapping, cross-utilised ingredients, separate listings
Hub and spoke	Central kitchen preps; small satellite kitchens finish and dispatch	Cold-chain transfers, batch labels
Shared kitchen / kitchen-as-a-service	Operator rents equipped kitchens to brands	Licence and responsibility split must be written down

RACI: **R** does the work · **A** signs off (one per task) · **C** consulted before · **I** informed after.

Code	Role
OWN	Owner / Founder
KM	Kitchen Manager (unit head)
SC	Sous Chef / Shift Lead
LC	Line Cook (station)
PK	Packer / Dispatcher
SK	Storekeeper
OPM	Online Platform Manager (listings, ads, ratings)

Code	Role
FSS	Food Safety Supervisor (FoSTaC)
ACC	Accountant

Licences and platform rules

Every virtual brand sold from a kitchen must show that kitchen's FSSAI licence number on its platform listing, and the kitchen must be on a commercially zoned premises with its own trade and fire clearances.

Rule	What the SOPs must do	Owner
FSSAI	One licence per kitchen premises (registration up to ₹12 lakh turnover, State licence above); all brands operating there listed under the same licence number on platforms; FoSTaC supervisor per 25 food handlers (FSSAI)	OWN, FSS
Menu information on apps	Platforms display nutrition, allergen and veg/non-veg information for chains with Central licence or 10+ outlets; supply the data per listing (Food Safety Works)	OPM
GST	Delivery platforms collect and pay the 5% GST on restaurant service orders under section 9(5); direct website or phone orders are taxed by the kitchen at 5%	ACC
Packaging	Food-grade packaging; single-use plastic ban items not used; EPR registration if you are a brand-owner introducing plastic packaging	OWN
Premises	Commercial use permitted by the municipal zoning; Shops & Establishments; trade/health licence; fire NOC where the floor area or LPG quantity crosses the state threshold	OWN
Shared kitchens	Written agreement on who holds the FSSAI licence, who is the employer, who maintains equipment and who answers to inspectors	OWN
Labour	Four Labour Codes; state rules on night shifts and weekly rest (iPleaders)	OWN

Rule	What the SOPs must do	Owner
Customer data	Customer names, phones and addresses from platforms may be used only as platform terms and the DPDP Act allow; no marketing without consent	OPM

Print the licence register and keep it on the kitchen notice board with the FSSAI licence on display.

Order lifecycle: accept to rider hand-off (OL)

The kitchen's target is an order packed and sealed within 12 minutes of acceptance, ready before the rider arrives.

Step	Target
Accept order	≤ 60 seconds (auto-accept preferred)
Kitchen start	Immediately on accept
Food ready	Per item; most items ≤ 10 minutes
Packed and sealed	≤ 12 minutes from accept
Rider wait at kitchen	≤ 3 minutes

OL-01 Accept. Orders flow into one POS or order-management system from all platforms; the dispatcher monitors tablets if integration fails; rejected orders need SC approval and a reason (item out, kitchen overloaded).

OL-02 Kitchen ticket routing. The KOT prints or shows on the KDS at each station with brand name, order ID, items, special instructions and allergy flag; one ticket per brand per order.

OL-03 Cook and assemble. Cook to the recipe card; portion by weight; plate into the brand's packaging; check against the ticket and the picture card.

OL-04 Pack and seal. Hot and cold items in separate compartments or bags; vent hot fried items to keep them crisp; seal with a tamper-evident sticker that shows the brand; add cutlery and napkins only if requested (platform setting); bag labelled with order ID.

OL-05 Hand-off. Rider waits at the dispatch window, never inside the kitchen; match order ID and OTP where the platform uses one; record hand-off time.

OL-06 Delays and cancellations. If an item runs out, mark it unavailable on every brand that uses it within 5 minutes; call or message the customer through the platform before changing an order; never send a substitute without consent.

RACI — Order lifecycle

Activity	KM	SC	LC	PK	OPM
Order acceptance	I	A	–	R	C
Ticket routing	–	A	R	R	–
Cook and assemble	I	A	R	–	–
Pack and seal	I	A	C	R	–
Rider hand-off	–	A	–	R	–
Item unavailability	I	A	R	R	R

Multi-brand production and packaging (MP)

In a multi-brand kitchen, every ingredient and every station is mapped to the brands that use it, so one stock-out or one slow station never surprises the team.

MP-01 Station-to-brand map. A wall chart lists each station (fry, grill, wok, tandoor, cold, dessert) and the brands and items it serves; peak-hour staffing follows the station load, not the brand count.

MP-02 Shared ingredient matrix. Each prep (gravies, marinades, rice, sauces) lists the brands and items that use it; the prep list for the day sums demand across brands.

MP-03 Veg and non-veg separation. Pure-veg brands use dedicated stations, utensils and fryers; listing says "pure veg" only if the kitchen truly separates; Jain items prepared in a separate area with dedicated utensils.

MP-04 Packaging spec per brand. Each item has a container type, size, lid, seal and label; packaging tested for leaks and heat retention on a 30-minute ride before launch; reviewed when complaints show soggy or spilled food.

MP-05 Holding. No pre-cooked hot holding beyond the recipe's limit (typically 30–60 minutes at $\geq 63^{\circ}\text{C}$ for gravies); fried items cooked to order.

MP-06 New brand or item launch. Recipe card, cost, allergens, packaging test, photo shoot, listing copy and price approved by KM and OWN; soft launch at limited hours; review ratings after 2 weeks.

RACI — Production

Activity	OWN	KM	SC	LC	FSS	OPM
Station-to-brand map	I	A	R	C	-	C
Shared ingredient prep list	-	A	R	R	-	-
Veg / non-veg / Jain separation	I	A	R	R	R	C
Packaging spec and tests	C	A	R	-	C	C
Holding times	-	A	R	R	R	-
New brand / item launch	A	R	R	C	C	R

Aggregator listing, ratings and growth (AG)

The Online Platform Manager reviews every brand's dashboard daily, because platform visibility depends on ratings, acceptance rate and kitchen-prep time.

AG-01 Listings. Each brand's listing has accurate photos (real dishes), descriptions, veg/non-veg marks, allergens, serving size, price, operating hours and the kitchen's FSSAI number; changes logged with date and reason.

AG-02 Daily dashboard review. Check per brand: orders, rating, complaints, cancellations, kitchen-prep time, rider wait, item-level reviews; one action per brand per day.

AG-03 Complaint handling. Reply to written reviews within 24 hours; investigate missing-item and quality complaints with the dispatcher and CCTV; record the cause; refunds per platform rules.

AG-04 Offers and ads. Discounts and ad spend set weekly against a margin floor approved by OWN; offers with clear terms; no fake reviews or incentives tied to ratings.

AG-05 Payout reconciliation. Weekly: orders, commission, ad deductions, packaging fees, GST collected by the platform, TDS/TCS; disputes raised within the platform's deadline.

RACI — Aggregators

Activity	OWN	KM	OPM	ACC
Listings accuracy	I	C	A/R	-
Daily dashboard review	I	C	A/R	-
Complaint handling	I	R	A/R	-

Activity	OWN	KM	OPM	ACC
Offers and ad spend	A	C	R	C
Payout reconciliation	I	–	C	A/R

Inventory, hygiene and facility (IH)

A cloud kitchen applies the same FSSAI Schedule 4 controls as any restaurant kitchen — chilled $\leq 5^{\circ}\text{C}$, frozen $\leq -18^{\circ}\text{C}$, core cooking $\geq 75^{\circ}\text{C}$, hot holding $\geq 63^{\circ}\text{C}$ — plus tighter control of packaging stock, which runs out faster than food.

IH-01 Receiving and storage. See the Standalone Restaurant manual BOH-02 and BOH-03; packaging received and counted like food, stored dry and off the floor.

IH-02 Daily and weekly counts. Daily count of proteins, dairy and top-10 packaging items; weekly full count; actual vs theoretical consumption by brand.

IH-03 Hygiene. Medical fitness certificates; FoSTaC supervisor on every shift; handwash and glove rules; rider area separated from food areas; daily cleaning schedule signed off.

IH-04 Pest control. Licensed contractor monthly; kitchens in basements or shared buildings need extra attention to drains and entry points.

IH-05 Ventilation and heat. Exhaust and fresh air sized for enclosed kitchens; temperature kept workable for staff (fans, spot cooling); hood filters degreased weekly.

IH-06 Fire and gas. Class K and ABC extinguishers; gas leak detection; two exits clear; staff drill every 6 months.

RACI — Inventory and hygiene

Activity	OWN	KM	SC	SK	FSS
Receiving and storage	–	A	R	R	C
Counts and variance	I	A	R	R	–
Hygiene controls	I	A	R	–	R
Pest control	C	A	R	–	R
Ventilation and heat	A	R	C	–	–
Fire and gas safety	I	A	R	–	–

People, shifts and finance (PF)

Shifts are planned around order peaks by hour, and every brand's P&L is reviewed monthly so that weak brands are fixed or closed.

PF-01 Shift planning. Staff by hourly order forecast (lunch and dinner peaks, late-night window if open); cross-train cooks on at least two stations; rosters published a week ahead within Labour Code hours and rest rules.

PF-02 Training. Day-1 hygiene and safety; station training with sign-off; packing standards for each brand; FoSTaC certification for leads.

PF-03 Brand P&L. Monthly per brand: net revenue after commission and discounts, food cost, packaging cost, allocated labour and rent, ad spend, contribution margin; brands below contribution target for 3 months reviewed for fix or exit.

PF-04 Statutory. GST returns on direct sales; TDS; EPF, ESI and professional tax; FSSAI annual return where applicable.

RACI — People and finance

Activity	OWN	KM	SC	OPM	ACC
Shift planning	I	A	R	C	–
Training and sign-off	–	A	R	–	–
Brand P&L	A	R	–	R	R
Statutory filings	A	I	–	–	R

KPIs and compliance calendar

KPI	Typical target
Accept to packed	≤ 12 minutes
Rider wait at kitchen	≤ 3 minutes
Order accuracy (missing / wrong item complaints)	≤ 1% of orders
Platform rating per brand	≥ 4.2
Kitchen-side cancellations	≤ 0.5%
Food cost	Set per brand (typically 28–35% of net revenue)

KPI	Typical target
Packaging cost	Set per brand (typically 6–10% of net revenue)

Frequency	Task	Owner
Every shift	Temperature logs, FSS present, item availability sync	SC, FSS
Daily	Dashboard review per brand, key-item counts	OPM, SK
Weekly	Full stock count, payout reconciliation, hood filter clean, offer review	SK, ACC, KM, OWN
Monthly	Pest control, brand P&L, statutory deposits	KM, ACC
Every 6 months	Water test, duct cleaning, fire drill, packaging spec review	KM
Annually	Food handler medicals, licence renewals, SOP review	KM, OWN

Sources

- [FSSAI FoSTaC](#)
- [FSSAI order on e-commerce menu display](#)
- [Labour Codes implementation](#)

Operational guidance only, not legal advice.